One Table, One List

A guide to the family meeting about what happens next for Mom.

Your sister talked to the facility. Your brother talked to a friend who went through this with his own father. You've been reading at night. Each of you is carrying a different piece of advice, and nobody has put the pieces on one table.

This guide is for one meeting with one job: leave with a single list of what the family knows, which decisions are the family's, and who is doing what. It isn't for choosing a course of action or settling who is right.

Who should be there

Mom, as far as she is able and wants to be. It is her care and her affairs on the table.

Then everyone who has a hand in her care, her money or her paperwork: the one who visits most, the one who pays the facility's bill, the one who lives far away and makes the phone calls. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests including everyone who is or will be part of the caregiving team, which may mean a family friend or a neighbor. [1]

Someone who can't come can send notes ahead. Pick one person to keep the list. It shouldn't be the person leading the meeting.

How to open

Send the questions below around beforehand, so nobody is surprised by them. An agenda prepared ahead of a family meeting is one of the things the Family Caregiver Alliance recommends. [1]

Then open by saying what the meeting is for, and what it isn't for.

- “We've each heard different things about what to do for Mom. Before anything else, let's get everything we've heard onto one list.”
- “Nobody has to be right today. Where we've been told different things, we'll write both down and take them to someone who can answer.”
- Say what the meeting is for: one list. Say what it isn't for: choosing a legal or financial step, or deciding when to apply for anything.

Questions to ask

Ask Mom, if she is taking part

1. What do you want us to know before we talk to anyone about your care and your affairs?

2. Is there anyone you'd like in these conversations, or anyone you'd rather not be?

Ask each other

1. Who has each of us talked to, and what were we told?

2. What do we actually know about Mom's care, her finances and where things stand with Medicaid, and what have we only been told?

3. Where have two of us been told different things?

4. Which decisions are ours to make as a family, and which need a professional to weigh in first?

5. Our three questions are what to do first, what needs to happen before we apply, and how quickly we can start moving forward. Who is taking them to your Medicaid planner?

6. Which papers are we still missing, and who will collect each one?

How to write down what was said

Keep one list. Mark each line Know (there is a paper, or the person responsible said so) or Told (someone said it). Where two people were told different things, write both and don't settle it. The professional you bring the list to will want to see both.

WHAT WAS SAID	WHO SAID IT, AND TO WHOM	KNOW OR TOLD	WHO WILL FOLLOW UP
"The Medicaid office is the place to start."	The business office, to Denise	Told	Denise will bring it to your Medicaid planner
"Start with a lawyer."	A friend, to Marcus	Told	Same question. Keep both lines.
The admission agreement and the facility's statements are in the blue folder.	Denise has them	Know	

What not to decide yet

These go to the professionals: legal questions to an elder law attorney, financial ones to a licensed financial professional, and what comes first to your Medicaid planner. Your list is what makes those conversations useful. Leave them open.

- Anything about moving, giving away or retitling money or property.
- Whether to sign a legal document.
- When to apply for Medicaid.
- Which piece of advice was right.

What you can decide today

- Who keeps the list and sends it to everyone.
- Who collects each missing paper.
- Who takes each open question to which professional.
- When you'll talk again.

Before you finish, read the list back so each person hears what they have agreed to do, and send it round in writing afterward. [1]

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't resolve a disagreement, choose a course of action, or tell you what a professional will say. It gets your family to one list, with the differences left on it. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family has one list now, with the differences left on it. The planning interview takes it from there: it asks about Mom's situation and gives you a free planning report that everyone at the table can read before the conversation with your Medicaid planner.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Who to include, sending an agenda ahead and reading back what each person agreed to do follow the Family Caregiver Alliance's guide to family meetings. The questions and the list are the Medicaid Planning Roadmap's own.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting